

SESSION 3A

WHAT IS REAL?

CLUELESSNESS TO TIME

What gets an average high school student motivated, stressed, or excited? What realities actually exert some control over what they do and how they feel? What do they actually respond to? What ruins or makes their day? In other words, **what is real** to them?

Usually, it has something to do with their social drama: whether someone smiles at them in the hallway; who will ask them to the prom; how cool their friends are; how they are regarded by others; and so on.

These things are of outsized importance during that season of life. And what older people want to tell them is that these dramas won't make a bit of difference in five years. And they won't matter at all in ten! In other words, the things that seem so REAL to them are not actually so. These matters that seem to loom so large now are forgotten in the long run.

A feature of youthful immaturity is being clueless to time. If something is a long way off, an immature person has a hard time thinking that it's real. For a child, something that is five years away might as well be 500 years away. We would say that youth are foolish to think this way, and that we are wiser, since we do realize that something five years out matters indeed. But what if something was 50 years out? Would your reaction be similar to a teenager's? "50 years? 500 years? That's not even real to me." That would be insane, yet many of us are like that. When things are a long time away, we have a hard time thinking they are real.

Additionally, we have a tendency to dismiss small consequences, even when we know they will accumulate over time. Things without swift, immediate consequences just don't feel real, such as eating unhealthy foods or not changing the oil in your car. The consequences aren't immediate, so we feel like we can get away with ignoring the issue. It seems like the damage caused is just not real. And therein lies our problem. The way we apprehend reality seems to fool us when it has to do with consequences that are far off.

The problem is that when it comes to ultimate issues of life and death and judgment, the time frame is measured not by years or decades, but by eternity. And the consequences of ignoring these questions are so subtle that they don't seem real. In other words, the most urgent and ultimate issues have a hard time pressing in on us.

INACCURATE REALITY

Our pulse on what is real seems to be inaccurate. For many Christians there is a disconnect between what we **believe to be true**, and what we **feel to be real**. Life is short; death is certain; judgment is sure; eternity is long. Yes, we believe these to be true. But who lives by what they think is true? We are bombarded by the tangible, and harassed by the urgent, so that what we actually respond to, or more accurately, react to, tends not to have much to do with the truths we believe about life, death and eternity. What actually drives our daily choices and occupies our thoughts are the immediate, tangible, and physical realities: the buildings all around us, the bus we need to step away from the curb to avoid, the tantalizing items pitched at us, the impressive people we see all around us. What is eternally and universally true—true for all people at all times, and forever—does not hold as visceral a sway over our lives as the immediate and physical.



Jesus warned against this very problem.

LUKE 17:26-32 (ESV)

²⁶Just as it was in the days of Noah, so will it be in the days of the Son of Man.²⁷They were eating and drinking and marrying and being given in marriage, until the day when Noah entered the ark, and the flood came and destroyed them all.²⁸Likewise, just as it was in the days of Lot—they were eating and drinking, buying and selling, planting and building,²⁹but on the

all—³⁰ so will it be on the day when the Son of Man is revealed.³¹ On that day, let the one who is on the housetop, with his goods in the house, not come down to take them away, and likewise let the one who is in the field not turn back.³² Remember Lot's wife.

Consider similar themes in another story Jesus told.



LUKE 14:16–24 (ESV)

¹⁶ But he said to him, “A man once gave a great banquet and invited many.¹⁷ And at the time for the banquet he sent his servant to say to those who had been invited, ‘Come, for everything is now ready.’¹⁸ But they all alike began to make excuses. The first said to him, ‘I have bought a field, and I must go out and see it. Please have me excused.’¹⁹ And another said, ‘I have bought five yoke of oxen, and I go to examine them. Please have me excused.’²⁰ And another said, ‘I have married a wife, and therefore I cannot come.’²¹ So the servant came and reported these things to his master. Then the master of the house became angry and said to his servant, ‘Go out quickly to the streets and lanes of the city, and bring in the poor and crippled and blind and lame.’²² And the servant said, ‘Sir, what you commanded has been done, and still there is room.’²³ And the master said to the servant, ‘Go out to the highways and hedges and compel people to come in, that my house may be filled.’²⁴ For I tell you, none of those men who were invited shall taste my banquet.’ ”

LUKE 12:54–59 (ESV)

⁵⁴ He also said to the crowds, “When you see a cloud rising in the west, you say at once, ‘A shower is coming.’ And so it happens.⁵⁵ And when you see the south wind blowing, you say, ‘There will be scorching heat,’ and it happens.⁵⁶ You hypocrites! You know how to interpret the appearance of earth and sky, but why do you not know how to interpret the present time?⁵⁷ “And why do you not judge for yourselves what is right?⁵⁸ As you go with your accuser before the magistrate, make an effort to settle with him on the way, lest he drag you to the judge, and the judge hand you over to the officer, and the officer put you in prison.⁵⁹ I tell you, you will never get out until you have paid the very last penny.”

As agricultural people were dependent upon the weather for their crops, they were good meteorologists. They were keen on sensing where the weather was going, or in today's terms, where the economy is going, where the hot jobs are, etc. But this was paired with a lack of awareness of a greater reality about “the present time.”

Review the passages and answer the questions below.

List all the things the people of Noah's time and the citizens of Sodom were engaged in. How would you characterize these activities?

Think about how clueless they were to what was actually about to happen. What lesson is Jesus trying to teach through these two Old Testament examples?

What factors does Jesus list as responsible for the invitees' lack of interest in the banquet?

What reality were the people of Jesus' day keenly clued into?

According to vv. 57-59, how should we "interpret the present time"? I.e., what should people prioritize above all other things? Why is this the case?

THE BEGINNING AND THE END

We need to wake up from the stupor of thinking that "eating and drinking, buying and selling, marrying, planting and building" is all of reality, and recognize that our life here is brief, that we are "on our way" to judgment, and that our highest priority must be to seek some kind of settlement before we get to the judge. THIS is the reality that confronts every mortal man.



JOHN 3:16 (ESV)

¹⁶ For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should *not* perish but have eternal life.

These are the dimensions of reality: love, God's only Son, believing, perishing, and eternal life. God, out of his great love, gave his only son, his beloved, that whoever believes in him should not perish, but have eternal life. These are the realities that form the framework of the gospel.

We need to live in this reality. This shift into God's perspective needs to happen in each of our lives. It needs to counter our bizarre sense of reality that says only what I can see and feel and touch is real.



REVELATION 22:12-13 (ESV)

¹² Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me, to repay each one for what he has done. ¹³ I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end.

Alpha and omega are the first and last letters, respectively, of the Greek alphabet. God is saying that our focus now, on the short term, is utterly narrow. It leaves out the past and the future; it leaves out God altogether.

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In fact, our past is God, and our future is God. God was there in the beginning. God saw you before you were formed; before you could form a word he knew you (Psalm 139). He is there at the end. He is the Alpha and the Omega. When history comes to a close, and the curtains fall, he is the one who will be there. He is the creator and the final judge. He's the one to whom we must all give an account.

Review the passages and answer the questions below.

Are you living with your end in mind? What shift in priorities would be appropriate for someone who is beginning to live with the end in mind?

OUR DEFAULT MINDSET

Our usual mindset, however, is to disregard the past and the future, and just simply assert the self in the present moment. Thoughts of our origin and creation, as well as our future destiny somehow seem out of place in our busy lives. The afterlife can wait, since for now we have our lives to live.

But is it OK to be unconcerned about our eternal destiny, and to simply focus on what we can touch now? The Bible does not consider this a neutral position. This kind of indifference regarding the most fundamental matter is culpable negligence and arises out of pride (Romans 1:18-21).

Blaise Pascal had some choice words on the matter:

Thus the fact that there exist men who are indifferent to the loss of their being and the peril of an eternity of wretchedness is against nature. With everything else they are quite different: they fear the most trifling things, foresee and feel them; and the same man who spends so many days and nights in fury and despair at losing some office or at some imaginary affront to his honor is the very one who knows that he is going to lose everything through death but feels neither anxiety nor emotion. It is a monstrous thing to see one and the same heart at once so sensitive to minor things and so strangely insensitive to the greatest.

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"I do not know who put me into the world, nor what the world is, nor what I am myself. I am terribly ignorant about everything. All I know is that when I leave this world I shall fall forever into nothingness or into the hands of a wrathful God, but I do not know which of these two states is to be my eternal lot. Such is my state, full of weakness and uncertainty. And my conclusion from all this is that I must pass my days without a thought of seeking what is to happen to me. Perhaps I might find some enlightenment in my doubts, but I do not want to take the trouble, nor take a step to look for it."

This negligence in a matter where they themselves, their eternity, their all are at stake...astounds and appalls me; it seems quite monstrous to me. ¹

- Blaise Pascal, *Pensées*

Review the Pascal quote and summarize below.

How does Pascal's quote apply to you?

¹ Pascal, Blaise. *Pensees*. New York: E.P. Dutton & Co., Inc.: 1958. pp. 57-58. Kindle edition.

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PARABLE OF THE RICH FOOL

In light of the Pascal quote, consider the story of the Rich Fool.



LUKE 12:16-21 (ESV)

¹⁶ And he told them a parable, saying, "The land of a rich man produced plentifully,¹⁷ and he thought to himself, 'What shall I do, for I have nowhere to store my crops?'"¹⁸ And he said, 'I will do this: I will tear down my barns and build larger ones, and there I will store all my grain and my goods.'¹⁹ And I will say to my soul, 'Soul, you have ample goods laid up for many years; relax, eat, drink, be merry.'" ²⁰ But God said to him, 'Fool! This night your soul is required of you, and the things you have prepared, whose will they be?'²¹ So is the one who lays up treasure for himself and is not rich toward God."

What was the man very mindful of, and very not mindful of, and how did this imbalance happen?

How much can you relate to this kind of imbalance in your own life?

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This man in the story is obviously quite capable. He knows what to do. He is building barns. He is amassing riches. He is moving ahead. He is building up walls of protection against the changing fortunes of life. He has got many years. He is set.

But he is a fool, because his reality is so small. What is real to him? His filled barns. His belly. He talks to his soul, but thinks his soul feeds on "ample goods." In this sense, the man is very modern. He narrowed down all of reality to himself, and then narrowed himself down to his appetites: "eat, drink and be merry." He was ignorant about his soul's true need, unconcerned about eternity, and couldn't care less about God. So, when he dies, he finds himself utterly unprepared to meet God.